

Mining Expert Calls

#1 China Economics: Resilience

Equities

Global

Basic Materials

We hosted UBS's Yu Song in Part 1 of our China Expert Call series

UBS Chief China Economist, Yu Song, sees a resilient China macro picture in 2026, with strong growth at the start of the year supported by exports and improving domestic demand; deflationary pressures have eased, whilst financial and geopolitical conditions have remained relatively stable. April data softened with slower growth and oil-driven inflation ([note](#)), which Yu attributes to policy tightening rather than structural weakness; Yu expects more supportive policy to lead to a recovery in economic data, given China's typically short policy lag. On commodity demand, we expect a continued structural shift away from traditional end use sectors (i.e. steel in construction and property) towards 'new' infrastructure and energy transition-related investment (i.e. copper and aluminium).

- Property:** The property market remains weak, but is showing early signs of stabilisation (in transaction volumes and sentiment) following cumulative policy easing. Our economist continues to see structural issues, e.g. demographic decline and excess inventory in lower-tier cities, which remain significant; as such, recovery will likely be uneven and concentrated in top-tier cities. Policy easing momentum has continued to wane for the sector (as growth in export & 'new economy' sectors offsets property market weakness keeping headline GDP close to the 5% target), with policy aiming to stabilise rather than reflate the sector. We believe commodity demand from the sector is unlikely to rebound in the near term as the focus remains on destocking existing inventory and property resales, rather than new starts; but the drag is reduced.
- Investment & infrastructure:** Infrastructure investment is expected to strengthen relative to last year (after a sharp decline in 2H25) and provide support for commodity demand. There is greater willingness to invest driven by the start of the new five-year plan cycle and policy emphasis on early momentum, particularly in the '6 networks' concept (i.e. energy, electricity grids, logistics, and other systems with focus on AI and national security). However, top-down messaging remains mixed with authorities encouraging investment while limiting excessive debt, which has introduced some uncertainty at the local level when it comes to execution.
- Consumption & trade:** Consumption is expected to hold up well but slow y/y, with likely diminishing impacts from subsidies; however, in the longer term, our economists see constraints from structurally high savings rate. Exports started the year strong (up ~15% YTD), whilst imports have also recovered reflecting improving domestic demand, resulting in growth surprising to the upside in 1Q.
- Structural focus of the economy:** Policymakers are becoming more confident, in Yu's view, supported by a stable macro backdrop and improved geopolitical conditions. At the same time, regulatory enforcement - particularly on private sector and fintech firms - is increasing. Structural policy priorities include innovation, energy transition, and economic security. The central government remains committed to its decarbonisation targets.

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